



TIPS & TRICKS



Access the complete command list with descriptions

Here is a command that enables you to see the list of commands with their descriptions (based on the packages installed in your system).

```
apropos -r "[a-z]" > List_of_Commands.txt
```

– Vijay Kumar, vijay@gmail.com



Displaying coloured output with the 'tail -f' command when a pattern match succeeds

GNU/Linux provides a very powerful set of commands. 'tail' is just one of them. It shows the last part of the files. Additionally, the '-f' option keeps the file in an open state and continuously displays the data as the file grows. But we often want to look at only certain lines and are not interested in the whole log file. We can achieve this very efficiently by combining the 'tail -f' command with the 'awk' command, which will show certain lines in a different colour when pattern match succeeds.

For instance, the simple command shown below will display a line in red colour if the pattern is present in the current line; otherwise, it will display the line in the regular fashion. Because of the different colour combinations, it becomes very easy to take a look at the required logs. By combining these two utilities, one can improve productivity greatly. Let us try this out with a simple example.

First, let us define a string to be searched:

```
[bash]$ export SEARCH_STRING="jumps"
```

Now search for the pattern 'jumps' in a current line and if it is present, display the line in red colour; if it is not present, display the line in the regular way.

```
[bash]$ tail -f output.log | awk -W interactive '{if($0 ~ "'$SEARCH_STRING'") {print "33[0;31m"$0"33[0m"} else {print}}'
the quick brown
fox jumps over ## NOTE: Only this line will be shown in
red color
```

the lazy dog

In the above example '-W interactive' option sets unbuffered writes to 'stdout'.

– Narendra Kangralkar, narendrakangralkar@gmail.com



Group commands and execution in the subshell

To group commands and execution in the subshell and then store the execution of the subshell in /tmp/all.out, run the following command in the terminal. Each command will execute in a subshell and finally get stored in /tmp/all.out. If one of the commands fails, then the subsequent command will not be executed.

```
$ (pwd; ls; cd ../elsewhere; pwd; ls) > /tmp/all.out
```

– Gururaj Rao, raogr@gmail.com



Single line execution to remove files and directories with filtered contents

We often need to remove all files and directories which are not 'LINUX'. Here is a command that will help you do this. We will skip all '.svn' and '.'

```
find . -mindepth 0 -maxdepth 1 \{ -type f -o -type d \} \{ ! -name "LINUX" -a ! -name ".svn" -a ! -name "." \} xargs rm -rf {}
```



Note: Please use this carefully as it uses a command to delete files and folders.

– Gururaj Rao, raogr@gmail.com



Open any application directly from the terminal with its default application

The 'xdg-open' command opens the default application associated with the file type directly from the terminal.

For example, the following command...

```
xdg-open http://opensourceforu.com
```